

A NEW SHADE BJP supporters celebrate with gulal after the party's victory, Kolkata, May 4

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

An SC/ST/OBC outreach, constituency-specific chargesheets, micro-strategies for slums and highrises helped the BJP cultivate multiple vote banks

benefits while embedding a communal edge into that package. When the TMC government expanded the state's OBC list in 2025, 76 new communities were added, of which 67 were Muslim—accounting for nearly 88 per cent of the additions. The BJP weaponised this issue with clinical precision, redefining OBC as "One-Sided Beneficiary Classes" and framing every Mahishya, Teli and Saha left outside the quota system as a victim of Muslim appeasement rather than administrative neglect.

Polarisation along Hindu-Muslim lines proved decisive, particularly among urban men. With the Muslim population disproportionately concentrated in the rural borderlands, the BJP created an outsized electoral advantage everywhere else on the electoral map, including urban seats. It won an overwhelming majority of the 68 SC-reserved seats and 16 ST-reserved seats, reflecting the depth of the Dalit, tribal and OBC coalition it had painstakingly built over two years. Its booth-management architecture—knowing which communities lived where, which grievances resonated with them, which workers could reach them credibly—all that came into play.

Other Weapons in the BJP Armoury

Union minister Bhupender Yadav, who was appointed central observer and played a key role in the victory, identified agrarian distress as a major electoral issue. His interactions with farmers in Hooghly and Bardhaman revealed widespread anger, particularly among potato farmers suffering repeated losses. The issue soon became central to campaign speeches by Modi and Shah. The BJP subsequently swept 16 out of 18 seats in Hooghly and 14 out of 16 seats in Purba Bardhaman.

Another strategic move was the preparation of constituency-based chargesheets. Led by BJP spokesperson Keya Ghosh, party workers conducted extensive outreach across 229 constituencies, gathering local grievances and documenting allegations against the ruling establishment. The 65 constituencies represented by BJP MLAs were excluded from the exercise. "We worked for five months compiling the data. Then, a team of 10-12 people at the state level worked on presentation and verification," says Ghosh.

The BJP leadership believes this personalised approach proved electorally advantageous and helped it fine-tune micro-strategies to attract different voter segments. In slums, the party highlighted promises such as monthly allowances of Rs 3,000 for women and unemployed youth, along with Rs 50,000 assistance for girls' education. In highrise residential areas, the focus shifted to employment, safety and civic amenities. The R.G. Kar case further consolidated women voters behind the BJP after Shah framed the incident as evidence that "women are not safe in Bengal". The BJP also pushed for polling booths within residential complexes to increase voter turnout, resulting in 69 such booths across 20 constituencies.

The cumulative effect of these efforts was to substantially erode the so-called "3 Ms" that had long sustained the TMC's dominance: Mamata, Mahila and Muslims. For Didi, the defeat marks the collapse of a political fortress that she thought was unassailable. But, for the BJP, Bengal is far more than an electoral trophy, it is a culmination of a decade-long ideological, organisational and political project to redraw the electoral map of eastern India. By completing its sweep across the Gangetic belt—from Uttarakhand to Bengal—the party has demonstrated an ability not merely to win elections but also the patience to reshape political ecosystems through relentless cadre-building, social engineering and narrative control. The Bengal victory will now be projected by the party as proof that no regional bastion is invincible and no political order permanent. It also poses a larger question for Indian politics: is it the end of the era of powerful regional satraps standing up to the BJP's unrelenting electoral juggernaut? ■